



MEONCROSS SCHOOL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

WHY HAS PEACE PROVED SO ELUSIVE IN THE MIDDLE EAST?

Paper 2: Conflict in the Middle East, 1945-1995 - Key

Topic 1: The birth of the state of Israel, 1945-63

Scholar:

Class:

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale		
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT 1.0: Broken Promises & Imperial Borders: Why Was Conflict in the Middle East Inevitable?			
L2: KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949			
L3: KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis			
L4: KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT 1.0: Broken Promises & Imperial Borders: Why Was Conflict in the Middle East Inevitable?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyse how the Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916) and League of Nations mandates drew artificial straight lines across former Ottoman territories.
- ☐ Evaluate the contradictory British wartime pledges: the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence (1915) versus the Balfour Declaration (1917).
- ☐ Identify the 4 strategic flashpoints of the Arab-Israeli conflict: Maritime Chokepoints, Elevated High Ground, Freshwater Basins, and Jerusalem.

Q1. Study Source A. Using the partition map, explain why the secret Anglo-French division of the Middle East in the Sykes-Picot Agreement laid the groundwork for decades of border conflicts and Arab betrayal.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which three continents intersect at the Middle East, making it a critical strategic crossroads throughout world history?

What vital maritime waterway, completed in 1869 across Egypt, connects the Mediterranean Sea directly to the Red Sea?

What narrow body of water at the southern tip of the Sinai Peninsula controls maritime access to the Gulf of Aqaba and Israel's southern port of Eilat?

Which elevated volcanic plateau in south-western Syria directly overlooks the Sea of Galilee and northern Israeli civilian settlements?

Which freshwater river forms the natural eastern boundary of the West Bank, flowing south from the Sea of Galilee into the Dead Sea?

Which ancient city is considered a sacred holy sanctuary by Jews, Christians, and Muslims, and claimed as a capital by both Israelis and Palestinians?

Which vast triangular desert peninsula connecting Africa to Asia served as a major military buffer zone between Egypt and Israel?

What secret agreement in May 1916 saw British and French diplomats use a ruler to carve the collapsing Ottoman Empire into European spheres of influence?

What official British letter in November 1917 promised British support for the establishment of a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine?

Why is military control of "high ground" like the Golan Heights considered an indispensable defense asset in modern warfare?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Select *THREE* terms that share a close historical connection. Identify which *ONE* remaining term is the 'Odd One Out' in this lesson, and explain your historical reasoning:

Sykes-Picot Agreement | Mandate | Balfour Declaration | Zionism | Arab Nationalism | Chokepoint

Q2. Explain why the borders drawn by the Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916) created long-term instability in the Middle East.

Q3. Study Source B. How did Arthur Balfour's pledge to establish a "national home for the Jewish people" create a fundamental and unresolvable contradiction with the rights of the existing Arab majority?

Q4. Explain the fundamental contradiction between Britain's promises to the Arabs (McMahon-Hussein Correspondence) and to the Jews (Balfour Declaration).

Q5 Strategic Flashpoints & Chokepoints: Match each critical geographic flashpoint on the left with its decisive military significance on the right:

1. The Straits of Tiran (Gulf of Aqaba)	• •	Israel's only southern maritime corridor for oil imports; its blockade by Egypt in 1956 and 1967 constituted an immediate act of war.
2. The Golan Heights (South-western Syria)	• •	Elevated volcanic plateau giving Syrian artillery commanding sightlines to bombard civilian Israeli settlements across the Galilee plain.
3. The Suez Canal (Egypt)	• •	Vital 120-mile maritime artery connecting the Mediterranean to the Red Sea, cutting 5,000 miles off trade routes between Europe and Asia.
4. The River Jordan & West Bank Ridge	• •	Natural freshwater boundary and strategic mountain ridge providing essential defensive depth against ground invasion from the east.

Q6. Why were the Golan Heights and the Straits of Tiran of supreme strategic importance in the Arab-Israeli wars?

Q7. By 1945, why did Britain face impossible, conflicting pressures in governing Palestine?

Guidance: Consider the dilemma facing the British government at the end of the Second World War: 1. Palestinian Arabs (two-thirds of the population) demanded immediate independence and an end to Jewish immigration, citing Britain's promises in the 1939 MacDonald White Paper. 2. Jewish leaders and survivors demanded that Britain tear up immigration quotas and create an independent Jewish homeland to rescue 250,000 Holocaust survivors stranded in European displaced persons camps. 3. Britain was economically exhausted from the war and caught in the crossfire of escalating communal violence.

SENTENCE STARTERS:

- On the one hand, Palestinian Arabs placed heavy pressure on Britain because...
- On the other hand, Jewish leaders and Holocaust survivors pressured Britain because...
- This created an impossible dilemma for the British government because...

Pupil Response:

Map Task 1: The Geopolitical Landscape of the Middle East

Understanding the physical and political geography of the Middle East is the indispensable foundation for understanding its modern conflicts. The borders of the modern Middle East were largely carved out by British and French imperial diplomats following the collapse of the Ottoman Empire after World War One. Control over vital maritime chokepoints—such as the Suez Canal, the Straits of Tiran, and the Persian Gulf—alongside access to scarce freshwater sources like the River Jordan, repeatedly triggered diplomatic showdowns and full-scale wars between 1948 and 1973.

Using the blank outline map provided in your workbook (and the reference map in your textbook), accurately locate and label the 9 key nation-states, 8 capital cities, and 8 critical maritime waterways/chokepoints that shaped 20th-century Middle Eastern history.

PUPIL TASK CHECKLIST:

 Countries (9):

- ☐ Egypt
- ☐ Israel
- ☐ Jordan
- ☐ Syria
- ☐ Lebanon
- ☐ Iraq
- ☐ Iran
- ☐ Saudi Arabia
- ☐ Turkey

 Capitals (8):

- ☐ Cairo
- ☐ Jerusalem
- ☐ Tel Aviv
- ☐ Amman
- ☐ Damascus
- ☐ Beirut
- ☐ Baghdad
- ☐ Riyadh

 Waterways & Chokepoints (8):

- ☐ Suez Canal
- ☐ Straits of Tiran
- ☐ Gulf of Aqaba
- ☐ Gulf of Suez
- ☐ Red Sea
- ☐ River Jordan
- ☐ Mediterranean Sea
- ☐ Persian Gulf
- ☒ Sinai Peninsula



Map Task 2: Israel & The Contested Territories (Post-1967)

Using the regional outline map of Israel and its immediate frontiers, complete the following geographical and historical tasks to examine the territorial transformations of the 1948 and 1967 wars.

PUPIL TASK CHECKLIST:

🚩 4 Immediate Neighbours:

- ☐ Lebanon (North)
- ☐ Syria (Northeast)
- ☐ Jordan (East)
- ☐ Egypt (Sinai Peninsula, Southwest)

💧 Strategic Water Bodies:

- ☐ Mediterranean Sea
- ☐ Sea of Galilee
- ☐ River Jordan
- ☐ Dead Sea
- ☐ Gulf of Aqaba

✏️ **Occupied Territories (June 1967):** (Shade with diagonal lines /// and label)

- ☐ West Bank (captured from Jordan – shade ///)
- ☐ Gaza Strip (captured from Egypt – shade ///)
- ☐ Golan Heights (captured from Syria – shade ///)
- ☐ Sinai Peninsula (vast desert buffer captured from Egypt)
- ☐ Jerusalem ★ (Mark with a star on the 1949 Green Line)



GCSE Exam Practice

Q8. Explain one consequence of the Balfour Declaration (1917) for Arab-Jewish relations in Palestine.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

EXAM STRUCTURE STRIP: THE 3-STEP PEE FORMULA (POINT, EVIDENCE, EXPLANATION)

EDEXCEL PAPER 2

Write exactly 1 focused analytical paragraph (approx. 5 minutes). Do NOT write an introduction, conclusion, or a second consequence.

[P] Point (Consequence): State ONE clear, valid consequence of the Balfour Declaration (1917) directly addressing Arab-Jewish relations in Palestine.

[E] Evidence (Contextual Detail): Deploy precise historical facts (names, dates, treaties, or figures) from 1917–1939 to prove what happened.

[E] Explanation (Causal Impact): Explain the lasting causal effect on Arab-Jewish relations or regional geopolitics using causal connectives.

Sentence Starters:

- "One consequence of the Balfour Declaration (1917) was the entrenchment of intense, long-term political and communal hostility between Arab Palestinians and Jewish immigrants under the British Mandate."
- "For example, following the declaration, Jewish immigration expanded rapidly during the 1920s and 1930s, accompanied by land purchases by the Jewish National Fund that displaced tenant farmers (fellahin)."
- "As a direct result of this British imperial endorsement, Arab Palestinians felt betrayed and disenfranchised, which consequently triggered widespread intercommunal violence including the 1929 Western Wall Riots and the 1936–39 Arab Revolt."

Causal Connectives: As a direct result • Consequently • This led directly to • Because of this • This meant that • Crucially

EXIT TICKET: THE GEOPOLITICAL PRIORITY VERDICT

EXIT TICKET • EVALUATIVE RANKING LADDER

Which foundational factor studied today created the greatest long-term obstacle to peace in the Middle East? Rank them from 1 (Most Destabilising) to 3 (Least Destabilising) and justify your #1 rank:

- Factor A: Contradictory Imperial Pledges (McMahon-Hussein Correspondence vs Balfour Declaration vs Sykes-Picot).
- Factor B: Artificial Borders & Mandates (European straight-line borders dividing historic ethnic and religious communities).
- Factor C: Strategic Chokepoints & Topography (vulnerability around the Straits of Tiran, Golan Heights, and Suez Canal).

Teacher Guidance: State your #1 factor and write 2-3 structured sentences using precise historical vocabulary (e.g., mandate, sovereignty, buffer zone, casus belli) to justify your choice.

Pupil Response:

L2: KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the conflicting interests and demands of Jews and Arabs within the British Mandate.
- ☐ Analyze the key events leading to the end of the British Mandate, partition and the creation of Israel, including the significance of the bombing of the King David Hotel and UN Resolution 181.
- ☐ Describe the key events of the Arab-Israeli war (1948–49).

Q1. Study Source A. Why did the Irgun target the British administrative and military headquarters at the King David Hotel, and how did this attack convince the British government that maintaining the Mandate was untenable?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which secret 1916 agreement between Britain and France partitioned the Middle East into European spheres of influence?

What official British declaration in November 1917 supported the establishment of a Jewish national home in Palestine?

What international body granted Britain the official Mandate to govern Palestine in 1920?

What was the political movement founded by Theodor Herzl aiming to create a sovereign Jewish homeland?

Why was the Suez Canal of supreme imperial importance to Great Britain?

What narrow maritime strait at the mouth of the Gulf of Aqaba links Israel's port of Eilat to the Red Sea?

Which elevated plateau overlooking Galilee was a major source of border clashes between Syria and Israel?

Which three world religions consider the Old City of Jerusalem sacred?

What freshwater river forms the natural boundary between the West Bank and Jordan?

What vast desert peninsula connects Africa to Asia and borders southern Palestine?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Mandate | Zionism | Irgun | Nakba | Dual Obligation | UN Resolution 181

Q2. Why did Foreign Secretary Ernest Bevin impose a strict immigration quota of 1,500 Jewish refugees per month, and how did this decision intensify Zionist resistance?

Q3. Explain two methods used by Zionist paramilitary groups during the Jewish Insurgency to undermine British control in Palestine.

Q4. Study Source B. Why did the execution and public display of the two British sergeants create such overwhelming political pressure on Clement Attlee's government to surrender the Mandate?

Q5. Explain how the bombing of the King David Hotel (July 1946) and the Sergeants Affair (July 1947) pressured the British government to abandon Palestine.

Q6. Study Source C. How does this photograph of the intercepted SS Exodus—and the global public relations crisis it provoked—explain why Britain's forced deportation of Holocaust survivors destroyed its diplomatic standing in the United States?

Q7. How did UN Resolution 181 propose to partition Palestine, and why did the Arab Higher Committee reject it?

Q8. Study Source D. Why did David Ben-Gurion choose to declare independence beneath the portrait of Theodor Herzl on the exact afternoon British forces withdrew?

Q9. Explain two reasons why the newly formed State of Israel was able to survive and defeat the invasion of five Arab armies in 1948–49.

Q10. By 1947, why did the British government conclude that the Palestine Mandate was completely ungovernable?

Guidance: Consider the triangle of pressure: armed Jewish insurgency, international condemnation (Exodus 1947), and severe domestic post-war bankruptcy in Britain.

SENTENCE STARTERS:

- Britain concluded Palestine was ungovernable because the financial cost of maintaining 100,000 troops...
- Furthermore, violent insurgent attacks such as the King David Hotel bombing and the Sergeants Affair...
- Ultimately, following the public relations disaster of the SS Exodus, Britain realized it had lost both moral authority and...

Pupil Response:

Historian's Corner: The Debate over Plan Dalet

Historians sharply disagree on the nature of Plan D. Traditional Israeli historians argue it was a purely defensive necessity to secure besieged Jewish settlements before the Arab armies invaded. However, 'New Historians' like Ilan Pappé argue the text of Plan D proves it was a deliberate blueprint for the systematic ethnic cleansing of Palestinian Arabs from the future Jewish state.

Q11. How does Pappé's interpretation of Plan Dalet fundamentally change our understanding of the Palestinian refugee crisis?

GCSE Exam Practice

Q12. Explain one consequence of the bombing of the King David Hotel (1946) for British policy in Mandatory Palestine.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

EXAM STRUCTURE STRIP: THE 3-STEP PEE FORMULA (POINT, EVIDENCE, EXPLANATION)	EDEXCEL PAPER 2
Write exactly 1 focused analytical paragraph (approx. 5 minutes). Do NOT write an introduction, conclusion, or a second consequence. [P] Point (Consequence): State ONE clear, valid consequence of the bombing of the King David Hotel (July 1946) directly addressing British policy in Mandatory Palestine. [E] Evidence (Contextual Detail): Deploy precise historical facts (names, dates, treaties, or figures) from 1946–1947 to prove what happened. [E] Explanation (Causal Impact): Explain the lasting causal effect on Arab-Jewish relations or regional geopolitics using causal connectives. Sentence Starters: • "One consequence of the Irgun's bombing of the King David Hotel in July 1946 was the collapse of British domestic and political willpower to maintain military control over Mandatory Palestine." • "For example, the attack killed 91 British military officers, civil servants, and Arab and Jewish staff, destroying the central administrative secretariat of the British Mandate." • "As a direct result of the escalating military casualties, immense financial costs (spending £40 million annually during post-war austerity), and public outrage in London, the British government consequently announced in February 1947 that it was surrendering the Mandate to the United Nations." Causal Connectives: As a direct result • Consequently • This led directly to • Because of this • This meant that • Crucially	

EXIT TICKET: THE THREE-TIERED GOLDEN SENTENCE

EXIT TICKET · THE GOLDEN SENTENCE

Write **ONE single, grammatically sophisticated historical sentence** explaining why Great Britain decided to abandon its Mandate of Palestine in 1947. Your sentence **MUST** strictly contain all three required ingredients:

- Ingredient 1 (Date / Stat): Include one precise date or statistic [e.g., July 1946, 91 deaths, £100 million mandate cost, or Resolution 181].
- Ingredient 2 (Individual / Group): Name one key historical individual or group [e.g., Ernest Bevin, the Irgun, Menachem Begin, or UNSCOP].
- Ingredient 3 (Causal Conjunction): Connect your cause and effect using an analytical conjunction [e.g., consequently, provoked by, culminating in, or whereas].

Teacher Guidance: Ensure your sentence clearly shows cause and effect, not just a list of facts.

Pupil Response:

Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the first Arab-Israeli War (1948–49). [8 marks]

Edexcel Stimulus Clues: You may use the following in your answer: • *The Arab invasion (15 May 1948)* • *The First UN Truce (June 1948)*. **You must also use information of your own.**

↓ CHRONOLOGICAL CHALLENGE (NUMBER 1–6)

- ☐ David Ben-Gurion proclaims independence; five Arab armies invade Palestine.
- ☐ Count Folke Bernadotte brokers a 4-week First UN Truce (11 June – 8 July).
- ☐ IDF secretly imports Czech arms via Škoda factories (Operation Balak).
- ☐ The "Ten Days of Fighting": Israeli counter-offensives break Arab sieges.
- ☐ Operation Yoav and Operation Horev drive Egyptian forces from the southern Negev.
- ☐ 1949 Rhodes Armistice Agreements establish the Green Line and divide Jerusalem.

🔑 HIGH-YIELD FACT & KEYWORD BANK

Yishuv David Ben-Gurion
 Arab Legion (Glubb Pasha) Count Bernadotte
 Operation Balak Czech Arms (Škoda) Ten Days
 Operation Yoav 750k Nakba Refugees
 Green Line (1949)

PHASE 1: OUTBREAK & ARAB INVASION (14–15 MAY 1948)

Cause • Action • Consequence • Link

PHASE 2: THE FIRST UN TRUCE & SECRET CZECH ARMS RESUPPLY (JUNE – JULY 1948)

Cause • Action • Consequence • Link

PHASE 3: ISRAELI COUNTER-OFFENSIVES & 1949 RHODES ARMISTICE AGREEMENTS

Cause • Action • Consequence • Link

L3: KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the territorial changes and their impact, including the refugee status of Palestinian Arabs.
- ☐ Understand the creation of the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) and the Law of Return (1950), and the importance of US aid to Israel.
- ☐ Analyze Israel's relations with Egypt in the aftermath of the war.

Q1. Study Source A. What does this photograph reveal about the fighting conditions facing the newly formed IDF, and how was Israel able to defeat the five invading Arab armies in 1948–49?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which international organisation was given responsibility for deciding the future of Palestine in 1947?

What was the number of the UN Partition Plan passed on 29 November 1947 dividing Palestine?

What percentage of Mandatory Palestine was allocated to the proposed Jewish state under Resolution 181?

What status was proposed for the city of Jerusalem under the 1947 UN Partition Plan?

How did Arab leaders and the Arab Higher Committee respond to UN Resolution 181?

On what date did David Ben-Gurion officially proclaim the declaration of the State of Israel?

What occurred on the day immediately following Israel's declaration of independence?

What was the Jewish paramilitary force that formed the foundation of the newly created Israeli Defence Forces (IDF)?

What Jewish militant group bombed the British headquarters at the King David Hotel in July 1946?

Which European superpower provided crucial initial diplomatic recognition and permitted Czech arms shipments to Israel in 1948?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Green Line | UNRWA | Law of Return | Fedayeen | Armistice Agreements | Resolution 194

Power, Governance & Warfare

Economy, Trade & Society

Q2. What happened to the territorial boundaries of Palestine as a result of the 1949 Armistice Agreements (the Green Line)?

Q3. Study Source B. What does this photograph reveal about the suddenness of the Palestinian flight and the immense humanitarian crisis created across the region?

Q4 The Refugee Deadlock Matrix: Complete the table analyzing the opposing policies regarding the displaced Palestinian refugees:

Dimension	Israeli Government Policy & Rationale	Arab States & Refugee Perspective

Q5. Study Source C. Compare the 1949 Green Line on the map with the 1947 UN Partition Plan: which areas did Israel capture beyond its original UN allocation?

Q6. Explain how the 1950 Law of Return transformed the demographics, economy, and security of the new State of Israel.

Q7. Study Source D. Locate the Straits of Tiran at the southern tip of the Sinai Peninsula on the map. Why was Egypt's naval blockade here considered an act of war (casus belli) by Israel?

Q8. How did cross-border Fedayeen raids and Israeli reprisal strikes create a dangerous cycle of escalation between 1950 and 1955?

Q9. Why did the unresolved Palestinian refugee crisis make a lasting peace treaty impossible after 1949?

Guidance: Consider how the refugee camps in Gaza, the West Bank, Lebanon, and Syria kept the conflict alive and prevented normal diplomatic relations.

SENTENCE STARTERS:

- *The refugee crisis made peace impossible because for Palestinians, peace without the Right of Return...*
- *Conversely, Israel could not accept the return of 700,000 refugees without destroying its...*
- *Furthermore, Arab host governments used the displaced refugees as political leverage to...*

Pupil Response:

GCSE Exam Practice

Q10. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the 1948–49 Arab-Israeli War. You may use the following in your answer: • The United Nations truce (June 1948) • The 1949 Armistice Agreements (The Green Line) You must also use information of your own.

[8 marks • 10 mins]

**EXAM STRUCTURE STRIP: THE 3-STAGE CHRONOLOGICAL LINKAGE CHAIN
(BEGINNING → MIDDLE → END)**

EDXCEL
PAPER 2

Write exactly 3 logically connected chronological paragraphs (approx. 10–12 minutes). You **MUST** use both stimulus points **PLUS** at least one development from your own knowledge. Show **HOW** each event directly triggered the next.

[1] The Beginning (Catalyst & Origin): Explain how the declaration of Israel and the Arab invasion on 15 May 1948 initiated the conflict (Stimulus: Outbreak of war).

[2] The Middle (Causal Turning Point): Explain the decisive turning point: the first UN truce (June 1948) allowing Israeli rearmament with Czech arms, Plan Dalet, and the displacement of Palestinian civilians (Own Knowledge).

[3] The End (Culmination & Resolution): Explain the culmination: Israeli military victories across the Negev and Galilee, the 1949 Armistice Agreements (Green Line), and UN Resolution 194 (Stimulus: 1949 Armistice).

Sentence Starters:

- "The 1948–49 War was initiated when David Ben-Gurion proclaimed the independence of the State of Israel on 14 May 1948, prompting five neighbouring Arab states to launch an immediate invasion."
- "A decisive turning point occurred during the first UN ceasefire in June 1948, when the IDF secretly rearmed with heavy Czechoslovakian weaponry and launched offensive operations (such as Operation Dani), which directly caused the mass displacement of over 700,000 Palestinian Arabs (the Nakba)."
- "This situation culminated in early 1949 with the signing of bilateral armistice agreements on Rhodes, which established the de facto 'Green Line' borders, leaving Israel in control of 78% of Mandatory Palestine while the refugee crisis remained entirely unresolved."

Causal Connectives: The crisis was initiated when • This directly triggered • A decisive turning point occurred when • Consequently • As a direct consequence • This situation culminated in

Exam Sources & Interpretations

Stimulus Point 1

The United Nations truce (June 1948)

Stimulus Point 2

The 1949 Armistice Agreements (The Green Line)

EXIT TICKET: SPOT THE HISTORICAL IMPOSTER

EXIT TICKET · TWO TRUTHS & ONE FALLACY

Below are three statements regarding the 1948–49 War and the refugee crisis. **Two are historically accurate facts; one is an IMPOSTER containing a classic GCSE examiner misconception.**

- Statement A: The 1949 Armistice Agreements (Green Line) left Israel in control of 78% of mandatory Palestine, significantly expanding beyond the 56% proposed in the 1947 UN Partition Plan.
- Statement B: The United Nations deployed an international military peacekeeping army in May 1948 that successfully enforced the borders of an independent Palestinian Arab state in the West Bank.
- Statement C: Under the 1950 Law of Return, every Jewish person worldwide was granted the automatic right to settle in Israel and gain citizenship, doubling Israel's population within four years.

Teacher Guidance: Task: State which statement is the imposter (A, B, or C) and write the 1-sentence historical correction explaining what actually happened.

Pupil Response:

L4: KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand Nasser and Egypt's leadership of the Arab world.
- ☐ Analyze the events and significance of Israeli attacks on Gaza in 1955 and Sinai in 1956.
- ☐ Evaluate the events and significance of the Suez Crisis (1956), including the formation of the United Arab Republic (UAR) in 1958.

Q1. Study Source A. Why did Nasser's charismatic leadership and anti-colonial stance inspire such widespread devotion across the Arab world?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What term do Palestinians use to describe the catastrophe of their expulsion and displacement in 1948?

Approximately how many Palestinian Arabs became refugees during the 1948–49 War?

What was the name of the de facto armistice boundary line drawn on maps in 1949?

Which neighboring Arab kingdom annexed the West Bank and East Jerusalem following the 1948 War?

Which Arab nation retained administrative military control over the Gaza Strip after 1949?

What legislation passed by Israel in 1950 granted every Jewish person worldwide the legal right to immigrate to Israel?

What was the unified national army established by David Ben-Gurion in 1948?

Which global superpower provided extensive financial loans and diplomatic backing to Israel in the early 1950s?

What was the decisive 4-week turning point in June 1948 that allowed Israel to rearm with Czech weapons?

Who served as Israel's first Prime Minister from 1948 to 1953?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:

Pan-Arabism | Czech Arms Deal | Nationalisation | Protocol of Sèvres | UNEF | Straits of Tiran

Challenge: Write ONE statement containing a deliberate historical misconception using **Pan-Arabism** or **Czech Arms Deal**. Swap with a partner to identify and correct the error:

Q2. Why did President Nasser turn to the Soviet Bloc for the 1955 Czech Arms Deal, and how did this upset Western influence in the Middle East?

Q3. Study Source B. How did Nasser use the nationalisation of the canal, as celebrated in this newspaper headline, to assert Egyptian sovereignty and fund the construction of the Aswan High Dam?

Q4. Explain why President Nasser nationalised the Suez Canal on 26 July 1956, and why Britain viewed this as an unacceptable threat.

PRETEXT INVASION

29 Oct 1956: Israeli paratroopers drop into Mitla Pass and sweep toward the Suez Canal, manufacturing an armed conflict.

COLLUSIVE ULTIMATUM

30 Oct 1956: Britain and France feign shock and order both sides to withdraw 10 miles from the Canal, knowing Egypt cannot comply.

CANAL SEIZURE

5 Nov 1956: Citing Egypt's refusal, British and French troops invade Port Said to 'protect' the Canal and depose Nasser.

Q5 Protocol of Sèvres Collusion Matrix: Complete the table below analyzing the secret conspiracy forged between Britain, France, and Israel in October 1956:

Conspirator Nation	Official Public Pretext	Secret Real Objective

Q6. Study Source C. Study the troop movements on the map. How did the rapid Israeli capture of the Mitla Pass and Sinai allow Britain and France to claim they were merely intervening as "peacekeepers" to protect the Suez Canal?

Q7. Study Source D. Why did Britain and France claim they were entering Egypt as neutral peacekeepers to separate Israeli and Egyptian armies when the Sèvres Protocol proved they had pre-planned the war together?

Q8. Why did the Anglo-French invasion of Suez collapse in humiliation, and what was its impact on Britain's global standing?

Q9. Study Source E. How did Prime Minister Eden attempt to justify military intervention to the British Parliament, and why did this justification collapse under international pressure?



WRITTEN CONSOLIDATION & RECALL

Recall & Analysis

Q10. Did the Suez Crisis represent a catastrophic defeat for Western imperialism, or a dangerous escalation of Cold War rivalry?

***Guidance:** Weigh how the crisis ended British and French dominance in the region against how it opened the door for Soviet and American proxy competition.*

SENTENCE STARTERS:

- *The Suez Crisis marked the definitive collapse of British and French imperial power because...*
- *On the other hand, it escalated Cold War tensions by allowing the Soviet Union to establish...*
- *Ultimately, the real victor of the crisis was President Nasser, who became a hero of...*

Pupil Response:

GCSE Exam Practice

Q11. Explain the importance of the Suez Crisis (1956) for British and French imperial influence in the Middle East.

[8 marks • 10 mins]

EXAM STRUCTURE STRIP: THE 'X LINKED TO Y' SIGNIFICANCE FRAMEWORK (2 FOCUSED PEEL PARAGRAPHS)	EDEXCEL PAPER 2
Write exactly 2 analytical PEEL paragraphs (approx. 10–12 minutes). Divide your analysis into (1) Immediate / Short-Term Importance and (2) Long-Term / Strategic Significance. Always explain the difference the nationalisation of the Suez Canal (1956) made for international relations in the Middle East. [P1] Immediate / Short-Term Importance: Explain how Nasser's nationalisation immediately challenged Anglo-French imperial prestige and provoked the secret Protocol of Sèvres invasion with Israel. [P2] Long-Term / Strategic Transformation: Explain how the American financial intervention and Soviet missile threats permanently ended European imperial hegemony and established the Middle East as a Cold War proxy battleground. Sentence Starters: • "In the short term, Nasser's nationalisation of the Suez Canal on 26 July 1956 was of decisive importance because it triggered a secret tripartite military conspiracy that brought the region to the brink of global war." • "This was demonstrated when Britain, France, and Israel secretly signed the Protocol of Sèvres in October 1956 to launch a coordinated invasion to seize the canal and overthrow Nasser." • "In the long term, the crisis fundamentally transformed Middle Eastern international relations by definitively ending British and French imperial dominance and establishing the region as a bipolar Cold War proxy battleground between the USA and the Soviet Union." Causal Connectives: In the short term, the nationalisation of the Suez Canal (1956) was of decisive importance for international relations in the Middle East because • This was demonstrated when • In the long term, this fundamentally altered • Crucially, the strategic impact was that • Ultimately, the significance of the nationalisation of the Suez Canal (1956) for international relations in the Middle East was that	

EXIT TICKET: THE CAUSAL BALANCE SCALE

EXIT TICKET • THE CAUSAL BALANCE SCALE

Weigh the historical outcome of the 1956 Suez Crisis on a scale of 0 to 10 for Egypt and Gamal Abdel Nasser:

- [0] A Catastrophic Military Defeat: Israel crushed the Egyptian army in Sinai; Britain and France occupied Port Said.
- [5] A Stalemate: Egypt lost military assets, but forced an imperial withdrawal.
- [10] An Historic Political Triumph: Nasser humiliated Britain and France, kept the canal, and became the undisputed leader of the Arab world.

Teacher Guidance: Task: Where on the scale (0 to 10) do you place the outcome for Nasser, and what is your SINGLE decisive piece of historical evidence from today's lesson justifying your score?

Pupil Response:

Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Suez Crisis (1956). [8 marks]

Edexcel Stimulus Clues: You may use the following in your answer: • *Nationalisation of the Suez Canal (July 1956)* • *The Sèvres Protocol (October 1956)*. **You must also use information of your own.**

⚡ CHRONOLOGICAL CHALLENGE (NUMBER 1–6)

- ☐ US and Britain cancel promised loan funding for the Aswan High Dam.
- ☐ Nasser nationalises the Suez Canal Company during a speech in Alexandria.
- ☐ Britain, France, and Israel secretly draft the tripartite Protocol of Sèvres in Paris.
- ☐ Israel launches Operation Kadesh, parachuting troops at Mitla Pass in Sinai.
- ☐ Anglo-French forces bomb Egyptian airfields and land paratroopers at Port Said.
- ☐ President Eisenhower threatens financial collapse, forcing Britain to accept a ceasefire.

🔑 HIGH-YIELD FACT & KEYWORD BANK

Gamal Abdel Nasser Anthony Eden
 Aswan High Dam Nationalisation (26 July)
 Protocol of Sèvres Operation Kadesh Mitla Pass
 Operation Musketeer (Port Said) Dwight Eisenhower
 UNEF Peacekeepers

PHASE 1: CAUSES & NATIONALISATION OF THE SUEZ CANAL COMPANY (JULY 1956)

Cause • Action • Consequence • Link

PHASE 2: SECRET TRIPARTITE COLLUSION AT SÈVRES & THE INVASION (OCTOBER – NOVEMBER 1956)

Cause • Action • Consequence • Link

PHASE 3: US FINANCIAL ULTIMATUM, HUMILIATING WITHDRAWAL & UNEF DEPLOYMENT

Cause • Action • Consequence • Link

Key Topic 1 Master Chronology: The Birth of Israel (1936–1963)

Master Chronology Challenge: Using your workbook notes and the event bank below, match each pivotal event to its correct year on the timeline and annotate it with one decisive historical consequence.

MASTER CHRONOLOGY EVENT BANK (MATCH & DEPLOY)

- 1936–39: Arab Revolt
- 1939: MacDonald White Paper (75k Quota)
- 1947: Sergeants Affair & SS Exodus
- 1948: Independence Declared & Arab Invasion
- 1949: Rhodes Armistice (Green Line)
- 1953: Qibya Massacre (Unit 101)
- 1956: Nationalisation of Suez & Sèvres Protocol
- 1937: Peel Commission (First Partition)
- 1946: King David Hotel Bombing
- 1947: UN Resolution 181 (Partition)
- 1948: First UN Truce & Czech Arms Resupply
- 1950: Law of Return Enacted
- 1955: Operation Black Arrow & Czech Arms Deal
- 1956: Suez Crisis & Eisenhower Ultimatum

1936–39

Arab Revolt & 1939 MacDonald White Paper

Specific Historical Details & Key Consequence:

1946–47

King David Hotel, Sergeants Affair & UN Res 181

Specific Historical Details & Key Consequence:

1948–49

Declaration of Israel, 1948–49 War & Green Line

Specific Historical Details & Key Consequence:

1950–53

Law of Return, Mass Migration & Qibya Reprisal

Specific Historical Details & Key Consequence:

1955–56

Black Arrow, Czech Arms & Nationalisation of Suez

Specific Historical Details & Key Consequence:

Late 1956

Protocol of Sèvres, Suez War & US Financial Veto

Specific Historical Details & Key Consequence:

End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Paper 2: Conflict in the Middle East (1945–1995)

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)

GCSE Exam Practice: Question Bank

Choose an exam question from the bank below and answer it on the blank lined pages that follow.

From KT 1.0: Broken Promises & Imperial Borders: Why Was Conflict in the Middle East Inevitable?

Q. Complete the geopolitical map of the Middle East by checking off each feature as you label it: - 🌐 Major Countries: Egypt, Israel, Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, Iraq, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Turkey - 🏛️ Capital Cities: Cairo, Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, Amman, Damascus, Beirut, Baghdad, Riyadh - 🌊 Waterways & Chokepoints: Suez Canal, Straits of Tiran, Gulf of Aqaba, Gulf of Suez, Red Sea, River Jordan, Mediterranean Sea, Persian Gulf - 🏞️ Key Peninsula: Sinai Peninsula

1. Explain one consequence of the Balfour Declaration (1917) for Arab-Jewish relations in Palestine.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

From KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949

1. Explain one consequence of the bombing of the King David Hotel (1946) for British policy in Mandatory Palestine.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

From KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis

1. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the 1948–49 Arab-Israeli War. You may use the following in your answer: • The United Nations truce (June 1948) • The 1949 Armistice Agreements (The Green Line) **You must also use information of your own.**

[8 marks • 10 mins]

From KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963

1. Explain the importance of the Suez Crisis (1956) for British and French imperial influence in the Middle East.

[8 marks • 10 mins]

Exam Practice Space (Page 2)

